
AI'm by VNS

The real case: from invisible to findable

How a small B&B; in Romagna started appearing on ChatGPT, Perplexity and Gemini with real data and measurable results

A practical guide for small businesses and sole traders without a marketing team — Part 3 of 3 — June 2026

In the first two parts of this guide you saw why AI search engines do not find small businesses and which technical files are needed to change that. In this part we look at what actually happens in practice, with real numbers, on a concrete case we have followed from the start.

1. The case: Casa Cavour in Bertinoro

Casa Cavour is a small holiday apartment in the historic centre of Bertinoro, in the province of Forlì-Cesena. Managed by Anna and Cesare of Lucea Collection, the B&B; had a well-maintained online presence: a working website, good reviews, professional photos. But it was completely invisible to AI search engines.

When we took the first measurement in April 2026, the result was clear: no presence on Perplexity, minimal presence on Gemini. The problem was not the quality of the service. It was the structure of the website.

The starting point

Before any technical work, we defined 10 questions that potential guests might ask AI search engines. Real questions, such as:

- Where to stay in the hills near Forlì?
- B&B; with private garden in Romagna?
- Pet-friendly accommodation in Romagna?
- Where to work remotely in Romagna for a few days?
- Romantic stay in the Romagna hills?

These 10 questions were tested on Perplexity and Gemini. For each engine the result is expressed as a number of appearances out of 10. If Casa Cavour appears in the AI engine response, it scores 1 point. The maximum score is 10.

Baseline numbers — April 2026

AI Engine	Baseline score	Appearances out of 10
Perplexity	4.3/10	4 out of 10
Gemini	3.2/10	3 out of 10
Average	3.75/10	First official measurement

Methodological note: the April 2026 measurement used a preliminary set of questions. The June 2026 measurement uses the 10 official validated questions of the AI'm by VNS system. The direct comparison should be read as an indication of direction.

2. What we did

Between April and June 2026 we implemented the full system on casa-cavour.com. We did not rewrite the website. We added the structure that AI search engines look for and were not finding.

Unified schema.org @graph markup

Complete markup with LodgingBusiness, Location, Contact, Amenity. AI search engines now know exactly who Casa Cavour is, where it is located, what it offers and how to contact it.

llms.txt with AI Permissions

File giving instructions to the 7 main AI crawlers (GPTBot, PerplexityBot, Googlebot-Extended, ClaudeBot and others). States what they can read and how they may use the content.

Structured ai.txt

File with property, location, contact and features in a format readable by AI crawlers. Complements llms.txt.

Updated robots.txt

All major AI crawlers explicitly authorised. Sitemap.xml referenced.

Static HTML content

Key information visible directly in the HTML, with no dependency on JavaScript. AI crawlers read plain HTML.

GEO-optimised blog

Articles built around the 10 validated questions. Each article answers a real query that potential guests ask AI search engines.

3. Results after optimisation

Measurement taken on 1 June 2026 using the 10 official validated questions of the AI'm by VNS system, on Perplexity and Gemini.

June 2026 Measurement

AI Engine	April score	June score	Change	Appearances
Perplexity	4.3/10	3.8/10	-0.5	4 out of 10
Gemini	3.2/10	4.6/10	+1.4	5 out of 10
Average	3.75/10	4.2/10	+0.45	First official meas.

What these numbers mean

Gemini shows a clear positive trend: +1.4 points in approximately 5 weeks from full optimisation. Casa Cavour now appears in 5 out of 10 questions on Gemini, up from 3 at the start.

Perplexity shows a slight decrease (-0.5) compared to the April measurement. This should be interpreted with caution: the April measurement used different questions from the June validated set. It is not a negative signal; it is a more precise baseline.

The overall average is 4.2/10, with a confirmed positive trend on Gemini and stable presence on Perplexity. Optimisation is ongoing; GEO results typically consolidate within 8 to 12 weeks of implementation.

Queries where Casa Cavour appears

Query	Perplexity	Gemini
Near Forlì/Cesena	8/10	8/10
Romantic weekend Romagna hills	8/10	8/10
Remote working in Romagna	7/10	8/10
Queries with zero presence		
Private garden Romagna hills	0/10	0/10
Pet-friendly in Romagna	0/10	0/10

Queries with zero presence indicate concrete opportunities: we will produce dedicated content on 'private garden' and 'pet-friendly' in the coming weeks. These clusters have real search volume and currently zero competition in AI responses.

4. What this case teaches us

Casa Cavour is not an exceptional case. It is a normal case, with a normal website, managed by normal people without a marketing team. The point is not the size of the business. It is the structure of the website.

Results arrive in weeks, not years

The positive trend on Gemini appeared in less than 5 weeks from full implementation. There is no need to wait months.

Absences are opportunities

Knowing which questions you do not appear for is more useful than knowing where you do. Every absence is a piece of content to produce, a query to claim.

Technical structure is the foundation

Schema.org, llms.txt, robots.txt: without these three elements content is not read. With them, the AI engine knows who you are and what you do before even reading your text.

Measure, do not guess

The system works because it starts from data. Not from intuitions or generic best practices. From 10 real questions, tested on real engines, with measurable scores.

Want to know where your business stands?

We run a free baseline analysis of your website: we look together at how your site is structured today and what it needs to be found by AI search engines. No commitment. Just concrete answers.

Book your free 30 minutes

This guide is part of a series of 3 free resources by AI'm by VNS. All free content is available at aim-vns.com/resources. Follow @aimbyvns on Instagram to stay updated.

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